

Why Experts Still Disagree on AGI

Even as tech CEOs tout looming AGI, leading experts remain deeply divided on *if* and *when* AGI will be achieved, and whether current AI paradigms can ever get us there. **Skeptics** argue that much of the AGI talk is hype – a narrative pushed by big tech to attract investment – while **optimists** believe AGI is both feasible and possibly near. Let's examine both sides:

- **The Skeptics (Hype Critics):** A chorus of AI researchers and critics caution that AGI is *neither imminent nor inevitable*, and that today's AI systems are fundamentally limited. Linguistics professor **Emily M. Bender** has been a vocal critic, describing the rush toward "AGI" as "*foolhardy at best, and deceptive and dangerous at worst.*" She and others argue the term *AGI* itself lacks a clear definition and mainly serves to "*feed the corporate AI hype machine.*" In a June 2025 article, Bender and co-author Alex Hanna debunk AGI claims, noting that **modern-day "AGI" chatter often repackages old ideas of "general intelligence" that have problematic, even eugenicist origins.** They highlight incidents like: OpenAI's Ilya Sutskever musing that "*today's large neural networks may be slightly conscious,*" a Google engineer wrongly believing an AI (LaMDA) was sentient, and the overstated "*Sparks of AGI*" paper – as examples of hype outpacing reality. Similarly, psychologist **Gary Marcus**, a prominent AI contrarian, insists that current AI (large language models in particular) "**are not a road towards what people call AGI**". Marcus has repeatedly argued that solely scaling up models won't achieve human-level understanding, calling for new approaches and pointing out the absence of robust reasoning or true comprehension in today's systems. Another respected voice, **Andrew Ng** – co-founder of Google Brain – has labeled AGI "*overhyped.*" In July 2025 Ng stated: "*AGI has been overhyped... for a long time, there'll be a lot of things that humans can do that AI cannot.*" He suggests focusing on practical AI applications, noting that fears of superhuman AI are "**just ridiculous**" given the current state of the tech. To Ng, worries about near-term AGI resemble "*overpopulation on Mars*" – distracting and premature. Even **Yann LeCun**, a pioneer of deep learning, while optimistic about AI generally, remarked that today's large models "*are not a path towards human-level intelligence*" and that he "*hates the term AGI*". In short, many experts urge *skepticism* toward claims that AGI is around the corner, pointing out the **huge gaps** between narrow AI prowess and the richness of human cognition (embodiment, common sense, causal reasoning, true creativity, etc.).
- **The Optimists (AGI True Believers):** On the other hand, some leading AI figures express *measured optimism* that AGI is attainable and coming, if not immediately

then within our lifetimes. **Demis Hassabis**, CEO of Google DeepMind, embodies this nuanced optimism. He commented that “AGI... *is a little bit overhyped in the short term*” – current AI’s capabilities are often exaggerated – “*despite that, it’s still underestimated how enormous a change it’s going to be in a 10-year timeframe.*” In other words, Hassabis believes **people inflate what AI can do today, but underestimate its future impact**. He has predicted human-level AI could be developed in the **next decade or two**, given steady progress and DeepMind’s work (DeepMind’s breakthroughs like AlphaGo and AlphaFold bolster his confidence that seemingly intractable problems can suddenly yield to AI solutions). Likewise, **Sam Altman** of OpenAI consistently voices that AGI is OpenAI’s goal and that it *could arrive relatively soon*. In fact, Altman in early 2025 suggested “*we could be getting to AGI this year*” – a statement reflecting his high expectations (though not a guarantee). OpenAI’s bold planning documents discuss not *if* but *when* AGI comes and how to **align** it. **Dario Amodei**, CEO of Anthropic (and former OpenAI VP), also leans optimistic about achieving powerful general AI *safely*. In a 2024 essay, Amodei speculated that AI systems **smarter than most humans** on many tasks could exist by **2026**, and might cure diseases or double human lifespan within 5-10 years after that. While he tempers that by saying it may “take much longer,” his vision is hopeful: he foresees **AGI as a tool for major breakthroughs in medicine, neuroscience, and more**, so long as we manage the risks. Notably, even optimists acknowledge uncertainty and pitfalls: Amodei explicitly distances himself from “*lofty prophet*” hype and emphasizes both **opportunities and risks** are underestimated by the public. Hassabis and Amodei, while optimistic on timelines, also actively engage in AI safety research (DeepMind’s and Anthropic’s safety teams) to ensure the transition to AGI is *beneficial*.

This split in perspective often stems from differing assessments of current AI limitations and how much improvement is needed. Skeptics like Bender and Marcus see today’s models as fundamentally lacking true understanding (*statistical parrots* memorizing patterns) – requiring new scientific breakthroughs to reach AGI, which might be decades away or even *impossible*. Optimists like Hassabis or Altman see a continuum of progress: each year models get more capable and “general,” so *if that trend continues*, human-level AI ceases to look science-fictional. There’s also a **philosophical debate**: what *is* intelligence and would an AI achieving high performance on most tasks by brute-force still count as AGI? Without a precise definition, “**What is AGI?**” **remains contested** – which feeds disagreements. As one Ars Technica piece quipped, “*Nobody agrees [on AGI], and that’s a multibillion-dollar problem.*”

Finally, *motivation matters*: Some experts accusingly note that **big tech companies hype AGI to attract funding and talent**, whereas academics not tied to those incentives tend to be more cautious. Billionaires like Elon Musk and Marc Andreessen tout AGI as both imminent and existentially risky, which Bender and Hanna argue paradoxically serves to *justify pouring billions into AI* under the guise of racing to control it. This dynamic has led to an almost ideological split: **“AGI true believers”** vs **“AGI skeptics”**, with plenty of middle-grounders simply unsure. In 2025, this debate is *far from settled*. As **Meta’s Chief AI Scientist Yann LeCun** observed, *“There’s no consensus on what AGI even means.”* So it’s no surprise that **experts disagree not only on *when* or *whether* AGI will happen, but on *what* exactly we’re even talking about.**